DAVIDSON COLLEGE
International Student Engagement

Alvarez Grant Program
Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

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Application Form in WildcatSync

Q: Can I receive funds for doing an activity in my home country?
A: Yes.

Q: I am planning to study abroad in fall but I need to make a down payment before fall semester starts. Can I submit an application during the summer grant cycle for a fall study abroad?
A: Only if you are *required* to make a payment to the study abroad program before the expected payment date of the "next fall" grant cycle. Make it clear in your application that you need the funds by a certain date and provide evidence.

Q: My friend and I are going to the exact same conference. We're going to share a hotel room, share Ubers, and cook meals together. Can we submit the same application?
A: No. It is unacceptable to submit the exact same application, word for word. Plagiarism is a violation of the Honor Code and will result in automatic denial of an application. It is okay to plan the same experience as your friend; however, you each need to write your own written statements in your own words.

Q: Can I apply for Alvarez Grant Program funding for work/research outside the United States?
A: Yes, you can apply to use these funds for work or research in your home country or elsewhere, if you can make clear how the work or research opportunity is connected to the field of your curricular or career goals.

Q: I'm a senior. Can I apply for Alvarez Grant Funds to support an activity or cost that occurs after I graduate?
A: No. Alvarez Grant Funds will only be awarded to support activities or costs that occur (are incurred) before graduation. The only exception would be in the case that an Alvarez grant is

pursued in support of a post-completion Optional Practical Training application. The final grant deadline for graduating seniors is the March deadline of each academic year.

Q: What do I do if I find out about an opportunity at the last minute?
A: Grant applications are not reviewed before one of the five deadlines throughout the year – they are not reviewed on a rolling basis. Students must plan ahead if they hope to receive either the Alvarez Access or Alvarez Guarantee grants. **Deadlines are firm and applications submitted after the deadline will not be considered.**

Q: I'm a first year student and want to visit graduate schools. Is this okay?
A: Freshmen are very rarely approved for grad school applications or visits because it's simply too early for them to be putting money toward this.

Q: I am in the interview stage and have not yet confirmed I will be accepted into the program. Does this disqualify me from applying?
A: That's okay! You need to submit the application prior to the grant application deadline even if you have not received the offer yet. If you do not move forward with the opportunity, you are required to let ISE know. At that time, we can approve a different opportunity or you can return the funds.

Q: Can I use Chat GPT or other artificial intelligence for the written statements?
A: You may use artificial intelligence (AI) programs (e.g. large language models like ChatGPT) to brainstorm and make your thoughts more concise, but statements, essays, etc. you submit should be your own work and ideas. As educators, our primary concern is preparing you to be capable, independent people. Be mindful that using AI may stifle your own independent thinking and creativity. If you submit work that is not written by you, it could disqualify you from this and other opportunities and call past and future work into question, damaging your credibility.

Priority Opportunities
The competition for grants is extremely high and, due to finite funds, the Alvarez Committee may have to prioritize funding during some grant cycles. Prioritization takes into account the activities that will have the highest impact on students' academic/professional outcomes. If grant awards will be prioritized, the list below shows the prioritization of activities.

Higher Priority
- Internship
- Study abroad
- Formal research
- Formal certificate program
- Presenting at a conference
- OPT and/or grad school applications

Lower Priority
- Attending a conference

- MCAT, GRE, LSAT
- Grad school visits

Items Ineligible for Funding

1. Classes at Davidson College (this includes elective music classes like MUS 55, etc.)
2. Entertainment and leisure activities (movies, plays) that do not have clear academic/professional purpose
3. Gifts
4. Start-up ventures in the U.S.

Budget/Funds

Q: If I am awarded a grant from another department on campus, can I still use funds from the Alvarez Grant Program?
A: We encourage all international students to take advantage of the many student funding opportunities which exist on campus (Dean Rusk International Studies Program, Center for Civic Engagement, Betty and B. Frank Matthews II '49 Center for Career Development (Matthews Center) and Davidson Research Initiative). If funds given through one of these programs are not sufficient to fully fund a specific experience, then the student may use Alvarez Grant Program funds to cover the remaining expenses if still connected to the student's curricular or career goals.

Q: Do I need to submit evidence of each expense?
A: Yes, that is ideal. This is especially important for expenses that can easily be found: transportation, accommodation, entrance fees, average cost of food per day in a city, etc. If you do not know the exact costs, we recommend looking at a cost of living calculator or some other resource to draft a reasonable proposal.

Q: I am submitting a request for funding to apply for application fees for 15 different grad schools. Do I need to show the cost of all 15 application fees?
A: Yes.

Q: Before I start my internship in California, I plan to visit family in Texas and then fly from there to California. Should I put the flight to Texas on my budget?
A: It depends. The Alvarez funds can only be used for expenses directly related to the Alvarez-funded opportunity. For example, if your family member is paying for your flight to Texas, and then you would need funding for the flight from Texas to California, yes, this is a valid use of Alvarez funds and you can put this fee on your budget. You could not, however, ask for funding for a flight to Texas (where you will not take part in Alvarez-related activities) and then a flight to California.

Q: I did not receive the full amount that I asked for. Can the committee reconsider?

A: There are plenty of opportunities to meet with an ISE representative to receive feedback before submitting a proposal. Asking the committee to reconsider is unfair to students who worked hard and used the available resources to submit an acceptable, complete, and timely proposal. Alvarez program grants are competitive and proposals that fail to deliver specific details and rationale will not be reconsidered.

Q: I have a balance on my Davidson account. Can I use Alvarez funds to pay for this?
A: No.

Q: The conference I was going to was canceled. How can I return the funds?
A: If you are unable to get approval for a substitute activity, then contact Sara Nobles in ISE. She will connect you with the Controller's Office who will charge your student account the amount and you can return the funds by making a payment to the college.

Q: Which study abroad expenses are appropriate to include in an Alvarez Grant application. Specifically, are tuition, housing, and dining fees eligible?
A: You can ask for the grant funds to cover the costs of the program expenses; however, the request may not be approved. When participating in an academic program (fall & spring), Davidson has to follow federal financial aid regulations which prohibit the school from awarding aid that exceeds the Cost of Attendance budget for either on campus or abroad programs. The maximum Cost of Attendance (COA) for a student is the total estimated cost, including tuition, fees, books, supplies, room and board, transportation, and other personal expenses, for one academic year of enrollment.

In many cases, students are expected to receive a refund of aid of which they are expected to use for their other study abroad costs, i.e. you may use those funds for additional expenses and to reimburse yourself for the airline ticket. We ask the Office of Financial Aid to confirm each student's max cost of attendance and how much we can award them before we send the award emails to students. So for example, if you are expected to get a refund to cover housing, and we have to deny the amount of your grant request that was for housing, you could instead use that amount for something else, for example an elective excursion while abroad.

Information Sessions and Workshops

Q: If I have already been awarded an Alvarez Access Grant in the past and I am now preparing to apply for an Alvarez Guarantee Grant, am I required to attend a mandatory information/grant planning session?
A: Anyone applying for the Alvarez Guarantee must have completed an Alvarez Info Session.

Q: I don't know if I should attend the workshop. I have an idea but I'm not sure if it's good and I don't have anything drafted yet.

A: That's okay! The workshop is a chance for students to bring their drafts, if they are ready, as well as to listen to the conversation, learn, and get ideas.

Rubric

Q: How does the rubric work?
A: The Alvarez Grant Committee has developed a rubric that will be used for evaluation grant applications. The new grading rubric will ensure clarity, transparency, consistency, and a focus on improvement.

- The rubric will take the entire application into account, whether you are requesting funds for an individual activity or a bundle of activities.
- The rubric scores 6 pieces of criteria (Description of Proposal(s); Learning Objectives and Action Plans; Budget; Evidence; Resume/CV included; Statement of Support signed and included).
- The score the application receives will be taken into consideration when determining the award amount.
- Applications that do not meet minimum requirements will not be funded.
- The rubric can and should be reviewed by students prior to submitting their applications.

Q: What happens if I receive a score that does not meet requirements?
A: Due to high demand and finite funds, the committee is implementing an approach in which not meeting the basic criteria means an applicant will not receive funding at all. As there are multiple resources available for students to craft an acceptable proposal prior to the deadline, there will be no appeal process for students who receive a score that does not meet requirements and therefore are not awarded funding at all. Students will be encouraged to apply in future cycles.

Q: What about the Guarantee grant?
A: The committee will evaluate the guarantees in order to help students learn and improve. Applications generally aren't denied unless the application is of poor quality or the project is blatantly unacceptable. However, the committee may decide to use the scores to determine small penalties as needed for a poor application.

Other Questions

Q: Does the additional programming and/or advising cost my family more in tuition and fees?
A: The Alvarez Grant Program is made possible through generous support from Malú and the late Carlos Alvarez. Mr. Alvarez was a former member of the Davidson College Board of Trustees. Thus, it does not increase tuition or fees. Grants offered to international students may

be subject to tax withholding and students should consult with the office of financial aid to confirm if an Alvarez Grant will have any impact.

Q: Can I be reimbursed for my experience(s)?
A: No. Funding for experiences must be pre-approved. A completed application must be submitted by the listed deadlines. The only exception would be in the case that an Alvarez Access grant is pursued in support of a post-completion Optional Practical Training application. The March deadline strictly applies to any activity taking place over the summer.

Q: How many times can I be awarded funding?
A: Students receiving financial aid from Davidson College are eligible for two Guarantee grants of up to $4000 each. Eligible students will only be awarded a maximum of two Alvarez Guarantee Awards – even if they request less than the full $4000 for each grant. This grant is of such an amount that students are encouraged and expected to "think big." Students can "bundle" experiences and propose multiple, relevant activities in the same grant application in order to make maximum use of the award, but the activities all must fall within the current academic year (and/or subsequent summer). Depending on availability of funding, students can supplement the $4000 using Alvarez Access funds.

Students with demonstrated need are eligible to receive the Access grant twice in an academic year (fall, spring, and summer); students with no demonstrated need are eligible to receive the Access grant once in an academic year. No more than two Access Grants and one Guarantee would be awarded to an eligible student in a single academic year.

Applications for the Alvarez Access and Guarantee grants all require timely, complete applications. If a student does not follow the application procedures, funds will go to other applicants

Q: What do I do once I've received funding and completed my experience?
A: Once the student has received funding and completed the experience, they must submit a completed Budget Reconciliation form; submit a reflection essay along with photos from the experience; and provide a "thank you" card/note/letter/photos to the Alvarez Family.

Unused funds greater than 10% of the original award amount must be returned to the Controller's Office.

Q: I received Alvarez funding to participate in a specific activity–but now I have received an internship offer and I want to use the money for that instead. Can I do that?
A: You must contact Sara Nobles in ISE to communicate the situation. If the new activity appears to be a valid use of grant funds, she will let you know the next steps.